

Texas Tech - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG 12

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-10 underlying quality and the clearest Big 12 title-level profile in the preseason model, but with more personnel replacement risk than the 2025 record suggests.
Preseason consensus	AP No. 12 (983 points) · SP+ No. 8
Returning production	63% (No. 21) overall · Off. 61% (No. 40) · Def. 64% (No. 18)
Primer power rating	+22.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	10.6 wins · likely 11-1
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar - Similar top-end caliber, with defensive regression risk offset by a favorable schedule and a top-10 model profile.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: OC Mack Leftwich surrounds QB Will Hammond with a deep RB room, experienced OL and expanded WR rotation. DC Shiel Wood must rebuild an elite defense with transfer starters and a more pressure-heavy approach.

Bottom line: Texas Tech has top-10 caliber and a favorable schedule, but repeating 12-2 quality requires QB Will Hammond and a transfer-heavy defensive reload to absorb a large NFL exodus.

Beats expectations if: QB Will Hammond keeps the offense efficient and DC Shiel Wood's rebuilt front recreates disruption; the schedule then creates an unbeaten regular-season path.

Disappoints if: QB Will Hammond struggles on passing downs and the new front cannot replace EDGE David Bailey, DT Lee Hunter, EDGE Romello Height and LB Jacob Rodriguez.

Five things to remember

- 2025 baseline:** The 2025 baseline was elite: 12-2, No. 3 scoring defense, No. 3 total defense and No. 1 rush defense.
- Quarterback:** QB Will Hammond is the current starter. QB Brendan Sorsby is not a 2026 option, and QB Tommy Castellanos is not treated as a completed Texas Tech arrival in this preseason baseline.
- Returning production:** Nine Red Raiders were drafted and five more signed as UDFAs; the defensive reload replaces multiple high-value starters rather than simply carrying forward 64% returning production.
- Receiver room:** The offense still has a deep skill foundation: RBs Cameron Dickey and J'Koby Williams, TE Terrance Carter Jr., WR Coy Eakin and several transfer additions outside.
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No. 72 (5/10 difficulty), and no rated opponent falls in the 35-65% swing band; the schedule materially raises the ceiling.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	12-2 (9-1 Big 12)	● Excellent
Scoring	39.4 PPG	● Elite
Total offense	461.4 YPG	● Elite
Rush offense	182.9 YPG · 4.6 YPC	● Very good
Pass efficiency	8.02 YPA · 33 TD / 10 INT	● Very good
Third downs	49.5%	● Elite
Scoring defense	11.8 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	258.3 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	68.1 YPG · 2.2 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	190.1 YPG · 5.51 YPA · 11 TD allowed	● Elite

Texas Tech paired elite scoring/yardage offense (No. 7 scoring, No. 10 total) with one of the nation’s best defenses (No. 3 scoring and total, No. 1 rush, No. 6 pass-efficiency defense). Third-down offense was also elite at No. 12.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+11.48 · No. 4	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.129 · No. 22	● Very good
Off. success rate	46.5% · No. 34	● Very good
Off. explosive-play rate	13.8% · No. 31	● Very good
Havoc allowed	15.0% · No. 62	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+12.44 · No. 2	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.322 · No. 1	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	30.3% · No. 3	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	7.1% · No. 3	● Elite
Havoc created	23.0% · No. 2	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Texas Tech's 2025 profile was elite on both sides, including No. 4 opponent-adjusted offense and No. 2 defense. The 2026 question is replacement, especially across a front hit hard by the NFL.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Joey McGuire - returning	● ↔ Program continuity is a clear stabilizer after a 12-2 season.
OC / play-caller	Mack Leftwich - returning OC/QBs; play-caller	● ↔ Continuity and a deep supporting cast help offset lower QB experience.
DC	◆ Shiel Wood - returning DC; Rob Greene promoted internally to co-DC	● ↔ Same system, but a rebuilt front requires a different pressure mix; exact game-day caller remains unresolved.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ WR Kenny Johnson	Pittsburgh	● ↑ Projected starting outside WR and major replacement piece.
♦ OL Jordan Church	Louisville	● ↔ Expected starting RG who helps preserve OL continuity.

Out	To	Loss
QB Behren Morton	NFL (New England), Round 7, No. 234	● ↓ Drafted starter leaves QB Will Hammond as the less-proven successor.
WR Caleb Douglas	NFL (Miami), Round 3, No. 75	● ↓ Material receiving production must be replaced.
WR Reggie Virgil	NFL (Arizona), Round 5, No. 143	● ↓ A second drafted WR increases perimeter turnover.

Offense net: ● ↓ **Slightly worse** in proven QB/WR continuity, but RB, TE and much of the OL remain strengths.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ EDGE Adam Trick	Miami (Ohio)	● ↑ Projected starting edge and first-team Big 12 selection.
♦ DT Mateen Ibirogba	Wake Forest	● ↔ Expected starting interior replacement.
♦ EDGE Trey White	San Diego State	● ↑ Likely starting edge in the rebuilt pass rush.
♦ LB Austin Romaine	Kansas State	● ↑ Anticipated starter with first-team Big 12 recognition.

Out	To	Loss
EDGE David Bailey	NFL (N.Y. Jets), Round 1, No. 2	● ↓ Major edge production leaves.
LB Jacob Rodriguez	NFL (Miami), Round 2, No. 43	● ↓ High-value second-level production leaves.
DT Lee Hunter	NFL (Carolina), Round 2, No. 49	● ↓ Interior anchor from the No. 1 rush defense departs.
EDGE Romello Height	NFL (San Francisco), Round 3, No. 70	● ↓ Another drafted edge raises transfer dependence.
S Cole Wisniewski	NFL (Philadelphia), Round 7, No. 244	● ↓ Starting safety leaves; S Malik Esquerra projects as the replacement.

Defense net: ● ↓ **Worse** than the exceptional 2025 unit, though major-role transfers and returning secondary anchors keep the projection strong.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Balanced attack built around RB depth, TE strength and an experienced OL.	Deep RB/TE/OL support and several viable WR options.	QB Will Hammond is less proven than QB Behren Morton, and the WR hierarchy is more transfer-dependent.
Defense	Pressure-oriented DC Shiel Wood defense rebuilding an elite front.	Returning secondary anchors plus several projected transfer starters.	NFL losses force pressure and run dominance to be recreated rather than assumed.
Special teams	Recognized returning kicker plus transfer punter.	K Stone Harrington is a major strength.	P Will Karoll is a transfer projection and SP+ ranks the unit mid-pack.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	QB Will Hammond is the starter, but he replaces drafted QB Behren Morton after an injury-interrupted 2025.
RB	● A–	● ↔	High	RB Cameron Dickey and RB J’Koby Williams return; RB Quinten Joyner adds upside if healthy.
WR	● B+	● ↓	Medium	WR Coy Eakin returns and transfers deepen the room, but two drafted WRs remove proven production.
TE	● A–	● ↔	High	TE Terrance Carter Jr. is a preseason All-America caliber centerpiece.
OL	● A–	● ↔	Medium-high	Four identified starters provide continuity; LG remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium	DT A.J. Holmes Jr. and transfers provide upside, but multiple drafted front stars are gone.
LB	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	LB Ben Roberts and LB Austin Romaine are recognized starters, but LB Jacob Rodriguez is a major loss.
Secondary	● B+	● ↓	Medium	CB Brice Pollock anchors a strong back end, but veteran turnover reduces continuity.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium	K Stone Harrington is highly recognized; punter is a transfer projection and SP+ ranks the unit No.54.
Coaching	● A–	● ↔	High	HC Joey McGuire, OC Mack Leftwich and DC Shiel Wood provide strong continuity.
Overall	● A	● ↔	Medium-high	Top-10 model quality plus schedule leverage, discounted for the scale of NFL turnover.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Will Hammond	QB	● High-upside but less-proven starting QB	-	The most important variable in converting a favorable schedule into playoff-level results.
★ Terrance Carter Jr.	TE	● National star / matchup centerpiece	AP 2nd · Big 12 1st team · Biletnikoff · Mackey	The safest elite passing-game role.
Cameron Dickey	RB	● High-end conference back	Doak Walker · Maxwell · Walter Camp Player of the Year	Returning lead back in a deep room.
A.J. Holmes Jr.	DT	● Conference defensive star	Big 12 Preseason DPOY · Big 12 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Outland	The interior anchor of the rebuilt front.
Ben Roberts	LB	● High-end conference starter	Big 12 1st team · Bednarik · Butkus	The most proven returning linebacker after LB Jacob Rodriguez’s departure.
Brice Pollock	CB	● High-end conference corner	Big 12 1st team · Bednarik · Nagurski · Thorpe	A decorated returning anchor in the secondary.
Austin Romaine	LB	● High-level transfer starter	Big 12 1st team · Butkus	Projected starter with major preseason recognition.
Adam Trick	EDGE	● High-upside transfer starter	Big 12 1st team	Projected starter in the rebuilt pass rush.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Favorable for a top-10 team; no rated opponent profiles as a true peer matchup.
Difficulty	● 5/10 · Moderate · SP+ SOS No. 72
Hardest stretch	at Oklahoma State → at Baylor → TCU: two road games followed by the strongest remaining rated opponent.
Swing games	-
Advantage	The Oct. 10 bye precedes Arizona State, and the schedule avoids every top-30 opponent in the rating set.
Expected	10.6 wins · likely 11-1
Floor / ceiling	9-3 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Premium pricing is likely after 12-2 and a top-10 SP+ profile; the counterweight is a heavily rebuilt defense.
Back them when	The price leaves room for defensive transition and the RB/OL/TE core can keep QB Will Hammond out of obvious passing downs.
Fade/pass when	Laying an extreme premium before the new front recreates 2025 pressure/run dominance, or if QB Will Hammond shows passing-down volatility.
Key monitor	QB Will Hammond health/efficiency, LG and final OL five, RB Quinten Joyner availability, front-seven pressure, defensive caller, QB Tommy Castellanos status
Week 1 baseline	vs. Abilene Christian: no independent preseason fair line; use the live market as the opening benchmark. Live market: Texas Tech –42.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Texas Tech brings top-10 model quality, elite 2025 efficiency and enough offensive continuity to remain the Big 12's clearest preseason title profile. QB Will Hammond is the key new variable after QB Behren Morton's departure.

The schedule is unusually favorable, but the defense must replace a large NFL class without losing its disruption. If the rebuilt front holds, an 11-1 season is a realistic baseline rather than an outlier.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [camp / roles](#) · [departures](#) · [team source](#) · [team source 2](#) · [team source 3](#) · [team source 4](#)

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